

UX Collective

Collected consciousness: AI product design for empowering human creativity



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Guernica, Picasso, 1937

Before we begin, I'd like you to take this painting in.

If you know the story, the details might already scream at you.

However, if you're unfamiliar with it, consider the content of the painting, read into the details, and build a story about it.

Try to understand why Picasso painted this.



Guernica, the town, Euskadi.eus

The painting is named after Guernica, the Basque town in Northern Spain.

On April 26th, 1937, about 6 weeks before the painting was unveiled at the Paris International Exposition, the population was about 7000.

In addition to the local civilian population, the town housed a communications center for the antifascist Spanish Republic during the Spanish Civil War, and so it was bombed by Nazi Germany and Fascist Italy — an intentional attack on not just the military forces, but the civilians that inhabited the town, to send a message.

Scroll back up and look at the painting again.

When you're done, come back here.

If you didn't know the story of this painting beforehand, now you do, and it might strike a different chord, if just slightly. The details of the painting now have the context that shows us what Picasso was thinking when he painted Guernica. The strained expression on the horse. The cold stare of the bull. The fallen soldier below the crying mother holding her dead child. The people of Guernica hold a candle that sheds a small ray of hope and growth for their fellow citizens while the light bulb, emitting no light, observes.

It's *this kind of context* that drives meaning in art. Guernica is not just a painting. It's communication. It's a very human way to express the feelings, experiences, and politics Picasso intended to express behind it. It's a vessel

of meaning built through words, actions, and paint. It's not just the product of a paintbrush hitting a canvas, but the product of a complex series of events and decisions made by its creator. *This* is why Guernica has become such a protected piece of art, and why we still know its story today.

And one day, that story will be lost to time. And, if for some reason, the painting has survived past its story, the people in this future can only speculate about what it means. But the details will be there, and the choices made by Picasso, expressed through those details, will guide the viewers to try and help them understand his feelings, experiences, and politics.

But this isn't an essay about art. It's about technology, and what it can and cannot do in art.

I started with this message because so much of our creative communication as human beings so deeply depends on the emotion, connection, and meaningful context created and consumed between the creator and consumer. If I (Brandon) tell you (the reader) I love you, that's very different from someone you actually care about, someone you have a history with telling you *they* love you. Real, true communication between people, especially through art, requires emotion, connection, context, and meaning.

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